BOBBY T. HICKEY

Operations Leader in Aggregates and Mining
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SUMMARY

Operations leader with 15+ years of progressive experience across aggregates production and heavy industrial manufacturing. Started as a welder and earned every step to Plant Manager. Proven across the full quarry leadership stack: crushing and processing operations, production planning, budget management and P&L accountability, maintenance planning, quality control, and safety leadership in MSHA regulated and union environments. Uses AI as a working tool for budgeting, maintenance planning, vendor cost analysis, and MSHA compliance, and writes about practical AI in heavy industry at Disruptive Depths.

CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

- Welder to Plant Manager across four companies: Dolese, Caterpillar, Vulcan Materials, C-Rae Materials.
- Currently leading a **greenfield quarry and aggregate facility** from site layout and plant commissioning through start-up.
- Led up to **40 employees** in union and non union environments; managed value stream and area budgets including an annual blanket PO.
- Production leadership at a **multi million ton per year** aggregates operation and on the **Cat MD6 surface mining drill** build.
- **Zero MSHA citations** across assigned area at Vulcan; **97 percent** Rolling Business Model attainment at Caterpillar; **30 percent** downtime reduction at Dolese.
- Built **AI-powered MSHA and OSHA regulation lookup tools** that answer safety questions in plain language with the exact CFR citation, used by about 35 people across Vulcan and C-Rae.

EXPERIENCE

C-Rae Materials | Quarry Operations, Fort Towson, OK

Plant Manager – Quarry Operations | *July 2026 to Present*

Greenfield start-up: standing up a new quarry and aggregate production facility from the ground up alongside vendors, planners, and engineers.

- Partner with contractors, equipment suppliers, and site planners to guide site layout, infrastructure, and plant setup toward safe, efficient operation.
- Build **MSHA and OSHA** requirements into the site from day one, using AI regulation lookup tools I built to set the standards, workplace exam practices, and documentation the operation runs on, and to train the team.
- Work with vendors to specify, source, install, and **commission the crushing and screening plant and mobile fleet**, using AI-built vendor price and cost comparisons to control spend.
- Establish the operating systems for the new site: SOPs, AI-built preventative maintenance (PM) schedules and tracking, and quality control processes.
- Recruit, onboard, and train the operations team, instilling a safety-first culture before the first ton is produced.
- Develop production plans and drive the site from start-up through ramp-up to **full, efficient output**.
- Own **capital spend, operating budget, and P&L**, managing cost and efficiency KPIs for the new operation.

Vulcan Materials Company | Southwest Division, Southern Oklahoma

Production Supervisor | *Oct 2025 to June 2026*

- Ran production across the wash plant, dredge, and pond fines at a multi million ton per year aggregates operation, leading a crew of 8 with direct accountability for throughput, labor efficiency, and yield KPIs.
- Consistently delivered production and yield targets month over month across the wet processing side of the plant: **100 percent attainment** of budgeted targets, tracked through AI-built quarterly production reports that kept results current.
- **Zero MSHA citations** across my assigned area, including a plant I helped shut down safely.
- Built safety ownership at the crew level, bringing the team into SIF observations to surface hazards firsthand, and giving them stop-work authority on workplace exams.
- Drove a strong safety culture through pre shift huddles, JSAs, near miss reporting, and MSHA ready documentation.

- Built and held an area budget in line with plan using AI-assisted planning and tracking, with vendor price and cost comparisons that **saved 30 percent**, while coordinating with vendors and supply teams to maintain parts availability and reduce downtime.
- Helped fellow managers use AI to track budgets, hit targets, and improve processes, and shared the MSHA lookup tool with the crew to raise safety awareness.
- Turned crew inspection lists into prioritized work orders, planned major downtime projects with the plant manager, and launched RCA discipline so corrective actions got completed and shared; used AI to analyze repeat equipment problems and focus maintenance on the key areas.

Caterpillar Inc. | Denison, TX

Production Manager | *Sep 2023 to Sep 2025*

- Ran the fabrication value stream in a union facility, including the team that builds the **Cat MD6 surface mining drill**: 40 employees, managing both the people and the budget through an annual blanket PO negotiated to run the shop.
- Hit **97 percent Rolling Business Model attainment** with higher production year over year using fewer people, while holding overtime under 10 percent.
- Led the fabrication team to the **first recorded world class welders at under 10,000 DPM**, and owned Built In Quality execution: containment and corrective plans for line defects, with field defect fixes verified across every machine.
- Applied Human and Organizational Performance principles and led SIF and PSIF response, convening safety, engineering, and quality to run fishbone and RCCA and implement prevention plans.
- Increased employee engagement 15 percent through coaching, development, consistent standards, and quarterly reviews tracked for every employee, and drove 5S, Lean, Six Sigma, and CQMS/ISO across the operation.

Operations Section Manager, 2nd Shift | *Feb 2023 to Sep 2023*

- Managed three value streams to takt time with a crew of 20, **increasing second shift productivity 30 percent** through continuous improvement and cross shift communication.

Dolese Bros. Co. | Coleman, OK

Leadman, Plant Operations | *Sep 2020 to Feb 2023*

- Led plant maintenance as leadman on nights, then days: prioritized the maintenance list, directed contractors on nightly work priorities, and scheduled downtime repairs across crushers, conveyors, and processing equipment.
- **Reduced downtime 30 percent** through improved troubleshooting and proactive maintenance, developed preventive and predictive maintenance programs, and worked with vendors to implement new processes that extended equipment life and improved plant efficiency.
- Tasked and trained operations and maintenance employees, pairing them with contractors and working alongside them so the crew learned maintenance hands on, building bench strength on purpose.
- Sat in monthly P&L reviews with the supervisor and superintendent, answering for production and downtime: where it occurred and why.
- Led the Near Miss Safety Program for three years and ensured full MSHA and OSHA compliance through inspections and best practice enforcement.

Welder / Head Welder | *Nov 2015 to Sep 2020*

- Oversaw all plant welding needs and several major capital upgrades; performed electrical and precision mechanical maintenance including motor and centrifugal pump alignment, screen unit repairs, and conveyor repairs.

CREDENTIALS AND SKILLS

- Six Sigma Green Belt | Associate in Business Administration, Grayson College: Summa Cum Laude, 4.0 GPA, President's Award
- MSHA regulated operations | Union workforce leadership | SAP | HOP | RCCA and fishbone | KPI system design | Maintenance planning and contractor management
- AI tools for operations: budgeting, PM planning, vendor analysis, compliance | Builds AI field tools (MSHA and OSHA Reg Lookup) | Founder, Disruptive Depths (Substack on AI in heavy industry)